

Hand Evaluation

Strength decides whether to open and at what level; shape decides which suit.



1 High card points

4
Ace

3
King

2
Queen

1
Jack

Milton Work's count: **10 points** in each suit, **40** in the deck.

♠ AQ854

♥ K9

♦ J87

♣ AKJ

18 HCP

2 The partnership's points

The more points a side holds, the more tricks it takes. As a guide:

20-24
part score

25-31
game

32-36
small slam

37+
grand slam

Cards from the 10 down don't count: here 3 + 1 + 4 + 2 + 3 + 2 = **15 HCP**.

♠ KJ73

♥ AQ5

♦ K84

♣ Q92

15 HCP

3 When to open

The opening bid is the first call other than pass: it's a choice, not a duty, and it depends on strength.

13+
always open

12
almost always open

11
sometimes, with concentrated honors

0-10
pass

♠ 93

♥ J7

♦ KQJ75

♣ K753

10 HCP: nice diamonds, but not enough strength

Pass

4 Balanced or unbalanced

There are three **balanced** shapes:

4-3-3-3

4-4-3-2

5-3-3-2

HAND	POINTS	OPENING
balanced	15-17	1NT
balanced	12-14 or 18-20	1 of a suit
unbalanced	12-20	1 of a suit

5 Which suit to open

1♥ and 1♠ need at least five cards; 1♦ at least four; otherwise 1♣, even with two.

With one long suit, open it; with two suits of five or more, open the higher-ranking.

♠ K2

♥ 4

♦ KJ876

♣ AQ873

two five-card suits: the higher

1♦

♠ AQJ3

♥ KJ62

♦ Q7

♣ 853

no five-card major, only two diamonds

1♣

♠ 53

♥ AJ4

♦ K9

♣ AJ10762

long suit

1♣

6 Strong openings

2♦, 2♥, 2♠: an unbalanced hand with 21+ HCP, or with about 8-9 winners. Open your long suit.

2NT: balanced, 21-23. 2♣: balanced with 24+, or a strong club-based hand.

Responder may not pass a two-level suit opening.

7 Preemptive openings

At the 3 and 4 levels: a suit of **at least 7 cards** with at least two honors, and nothing outside. The message: "on my own I take 3 tricks fewer than I bid."

♠ AKQ9653

♥ 2

♦ 65

♣ 873

7 winners

4♠

♠ —

♥ 843

♦ KQJ8763

♣ 972

6 winners

3♦